

CRM Recommendation: Marketing/Sales Ecosystem for RetailzPOS & Moolah Points Ad Campaigns

Prepared: July 2026 **Scope:** A CRM to sit at the center of upcoming Google Ads + Meta Ads campaigns for RetailzPOS (and future products like Moolah Points) — capturing UTM-tagged leads, connecting to GA4, reporting MQLs to marketing, notifying sales on new leads, and providing campaign KPI monitoring.

What this actually requires (translating the ask into a checklist)

Before comparing tools, worth being precise about what "connects with GA4, pulls UTM-tagged ad leads, reports MQLs, notifies sales" really breaks down into — six distinct capabilities, not one:

1. **UTM capture at the point of conversion** — a form/landing page that reads `utm_source`, `utm_medium`, `utm_campaign`, `gclid` / `fbclid` and attaches them to the new lead record automatically.
2. **CRM ↔ GA4 connection** — so ad spend and on-site behavior (GA4) can be joined with what actually became a lead/deal (CRM) for true cost-per-lead and cost-per-customer reporting.
3. **Native or near-native Google Ads / Meta Ads integration** — pulling campaign/ad-set data in, and ideally pushing conversion events back out so the ad platforms can optimize toward real leads, not just clicks.
4. **MQL definition and reporting** — a lifecycle stage or score that marketing can point to and say "these X leads this month were marketing-qualified," distinct from raw form fills.
5. **Real-time sales notification** — the moment a lead converts, a rep gets pinged (email/Slack/mobile) with enough context to follow up fast.
6. **Campaign KPI dashboarding** — cost/lead, cost/MQL, lead → deal conversion rate, by campaign/ad/channel, in one place both teams look at.

Important honesty check before the recommendations: no CRM in this budget range does all six of these with zero integration glue. Even the most "native" option here (HubSpot) needs a paid tier jump for the deepest ad-platform feedback loop. Every option below will involve either a built-in connector, a middleware tool (Zapier/Make/Albato), or both — that's normal, not a red flag on any specific tool.

The 3 recommendations

1. HubSpot — best out-of-box fit, but the real ecosystem lives one tier up

Pricing (2026): Starter Customer Platform bundle — \$15–20/seat/month annual (HubSpot has run new-customer promos as low as \$9/seat/month). Includes Marketing Hub Starter (1,000 contacts), Sales Hub Starter, Service Hub Starter in one bundle. [Sources: resonatehq.com, saascrmreview.com HubSpot pricing guides]

What you get at Starter: - Native forms/landing pages with automatic UTM capture into contact records — this part is genuinely turnkey. - **Marketing Qualified Lead is a built-in, standard lifecycle stage** in HubSpot's data

model — not something you have to invent. This is the single strongest reason to consider HubSpot: MQL reporting is a native concept, not a custom field you build yourself. - Basic ad tracking/reporting and simple workflow-based sales notifications (email/in-app) work at Starter.

The honest catch: the deeper ad-platform integration — syncing custom audiences back to Google/Meta, and sending conversion events back to the ad platforms so they optimize toward real leads (not just form fills) — **requires Marketing Hub Professional**, which runs **\$800–890/month plus a \$3,000 one-time onboarding fee** (2,000 contacts included, +\$250/mo per additional 5,000). [Source: HubSpot pricing guides via Cargas, sendx.io] That's a steep jump from Starter, and it's the kind of thing that looks "cheap" until you need the feature that made you want HubSpot in the first place.

Fit against the checklist: UTM capture — native. GA4 connection — via HubSpot's own analytics or a connector (not identical to native GA4, but solid). Google/Meta Ads integration — Professional+, limited at Starter. MQL reporting — best-in-class, native concept. Sales notifications — Starter. KPI dashboards — richest of the three, especially at Professional.

2. Zoho CRM — best value, more setup work

Pricing (2026, annual billing): Standard \$14/user/mo, Professional \$23/user/mo, Enterprise \$40/user/mo, Ultimate \$52/user/mo (roughly 40-70% higher on month-to-month billing). Free plan available for up to 3 users. [Source: G2, Method, SaaSwothy Zoho pricing guides]

What you get: Zoho CRM's own UTM/lead-source tracking is solid, and it's part of the much larger Zoho One ecosystem (Zoho Marketing Automation, Zoho Flow, Zoho Analytics) if you want to grow into it. But — **native Google Ads and Meta Ads integration is thinner than HubSpot's:** most real-world setups use a third-party connector (GA Connector, LeadsBridge) or Zoho's own Zoho Flow to bridge Ads ↔ CRM ↔ GA4, rather than one native pane doing it all. [Source: GA Connector, LeadsBridge, Zoho community/help docs] This isn't a dealbreaker — it's a very standard pattern — but budget half a day of setup work with an integration tool, not a two-click native connect.

MQL isn't a built-in concept the way it is in HubSpot; you'd build it as a custom field + scoring rule, which Zoho supports fine but requires you to define the logic yourself.

Fit against the checklist: UTM capture — native. GA4 connection — via connector. Google/Meta Ads integration — via connector, not fully native. MQL reporting — build-your-own via custom fields/scoring rules. Sales notifications — workflow-based, available at Standard tier. KPI dashboards — decent natively, richer with Zoho Analytics add-on.

Best for: the most budget-conscious pick that still covers everything — if you (or someone on the team) is comfortable spending a bit of setup time wiring connectors, Zoho's cost-to-capability ratio is hard to beat.

3. Freshsales (Freshworks CRM) — the middle ground

Pricing (2026, annual billing): Free plan up to 3 users. Paid tiers roughly: Growth ~\$11/user/mo, Pro ~\$47/user/mo, Enterprise ~\$71/user/mo. [Source: saascrmreview.com, emailtooltester.com Freshsales pricing guides — verify exact current figures at freshworks.com before committing, as billing-term naming shifts periodically]

What you get: Freshsales' standout feature for this use case is **native AI-powered lead scoring** — a real, built-in engine that ranks leads on explicit (demographic) and implicit (behavioral) signals, which is a more direct

MQL-identification tool than what Zoho offers out of the box. Google Ads integration is well-documented and supported multiple ways (native app plus several third-party connector options); Meta Ads and GA4 both typically go through a connector (Albato is commonly used for GA4, and it's a genuinely quick no-code setup — not a heavy lift). [Source: Freshworks lead management docs, Albato, easyinsights.ai]

Workflow automation for instant sales notifications is solid and comparable to the other two.

Fit against the checklist: UTM capture native. GA4 connection via connector (quick to set up). Google/Meta Ads integration Google via native app, Meta via connector. MQL reporting genuine native lead-scoring engine, stronger than Zoho's out-of-box story. Sales notifications . KPI dashboards solid, cleaner UI than Zoho for most users.

Best for: a team that wants HubSpot-like lead-scoring polish without HubSpot's Professional-tier price cliff, and doesn't mind a lightweight connector for GA4/Meta.

Comparison table

	HubSpot (Starter)	Zoho CRM (Standard/Pro)	Freshsales (Growth/Pro)
Entry price	~\$15–20/seat/mo	\$14–23/user/mo	~\$11–47/user/mo
UTM capture	Native	Native	Native
GA4 connection	HubSpot analytics + connector	Connector (GA Connector)	Connector (Albato)
Google Ads integration	Native (deeper features at Pro)	Connector	Native app
Meta Ads integration	Native (deeper features at Pro)	Connector (LeadsBridge)	Connector
MQL as a native concept	Yes, built-in lifecycle stage	Build your own	Native lead scoring
Real-time sales notification			
KPI/campaign dashboards	Richest	Decent	Solid
Price to unlock full ad-platform feedback loop	\$800–890/mo (Marketing Hub Pro) + \$3,000 onboarding	Included in mid-tier + connector cost	Included in mid-tier + connector cost

Recommendation

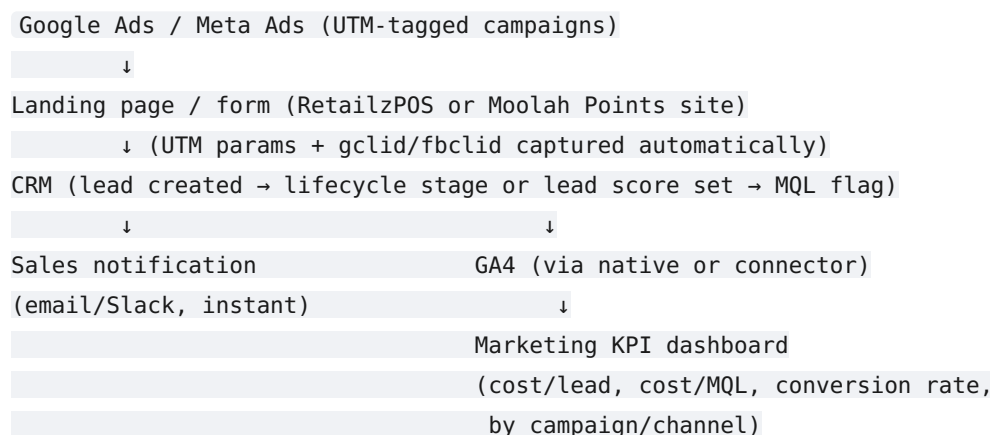
Given "not too expensive" is a real constraint and you're running this for **two products at once** (RetailzPOS now, Moolah Points likely soon after) — the same CRM instance can serve both if you separate them by pipeline/deal-type rather than needing two subscriptions.

- **If budget allows ~\$50-150/user/month and you want the most polished, least-DIY experience with MQL reporting that just works out of the box:** start with **HubSpot Starter**, and treat the Marketing Hub Professional jump as a milestone to hit once ad spend is proving out (i.e., once you *know* the ads are working and want the deeper audience-sync/conversion-feedback loop) rather than a day-one requirement.

- If budget is the primary constraint and someone on the team has an afternoon to spend wiring up a connector: **Zoho CRM Standard or Professional** gives you everything at the lowest cost, with the tradeoff that MQL scoring and GA4/Ads bridging take real setup work rather than being turnkey.
- If you want a middle ground — real native lead scoring, a cleaner UI than Zoho, without HubSpot's Professional-tier price cliff: **Freshsales Growth or Pro** is the balanced pick.

My default suggestion: start with **Freshsales Growth or Zoho CRM Standard** for the pilot campaign (low commitment, both cover the checklist with modest setup), and treat **HubSpot Starter** as the upgrade path if the marketing/sales handoff process outgrows the simpler tools — HubSpot's native MQL concept and richer dashboards are worth paying for once you have enough lead volume that manual scoring/reporting setup becomes the bottleneck, not before.

Suggested architecture (works with any of the three)



Sources: resonatehq.com, saascrmreview.com, sendx.io, cargas.com (HubSpot pricing); G2, Method, SaaSwothy, layer3labs.io (Zoho CRM pricing); saascrmreview.com, emailtooltester.com (Freshsales pricing); GA Connector, LeadsBridge, Albato, easyinsights.ai (integration specifics). Pricing changes frequently — verify current figures directly with each vendor before purchasing.